# What Is Attribution?

**Attribution** refers to the process of explaining the causes of behaviour and events. It answers the fundamental question: *"Why did this happen?"*

## The Core Idea

When we observe someone acting in a certain way, our minds automatically search for an explanation. This mental reasoning process helps us understand, predict, and respond to the world around us.

## Why It Matters

Attribution shapes how we perceive others' intentions and character. It influences our emotional responses, social relationships, and even our judgements in high-stakes situations such as classrooms, courtrooms, and workplaces.

Attribution is not always accurate — it is a **mental shortcut**, subject to bias and error.

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# Types of Attribution

When explaining behaviour, we typically attribute causes to one of two broad categories — **internal** (within the person) or **external** (outside the person). Understanding this distinction is foundational to all attribution theories.

### 🧠 Internal (Dispositional)

The cause is located **within the person** — their personality, ability, intelligence, motivation, or effort.

*Example: "She failed the exam because she didn't study hard enough."*

### 🌍 External (Situational)

The cause is located **outside the person** — the environment, luck, task difficulty, or social pressure.

*Example: "She failed the exam because it was unreasonably difficult."*

ⓘ The same event can be explained in both ways — which attribution we choose reveals a great deal about our own biases and assumptions.

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# Theories of Attribution

An introduction to how we explain the world around us — exploring **Correspondent Inference Theory** and **Causal Attribution Theory**, and how attitudes shape our everyday thinking and behaviour.

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# Why Do People Behave the Way They Do?

Every day, we observe the actions of those around us and instinctively ask: *Why did they do that?* This mental process — searching for the causes behind behaviour — is at the heart of social psychology.

## We Seek Explanations

Humans are natural sense-makers. We rarely accept behaviour at face value — we probe for underlying motives, traits, and circumstances.

## This Process Is Called Attribution

Attribution is the cognitive process by which we assign causes to events and the actions of others — forming the basis of our social judgements.

## It Shapes Everyday Decisions

Whether we blame, praise, trust, or avoid someone often comes down to the attributions we make — making this one of the most practical areas of psychology.

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# Correspondent Inference Theory

JONES & DAVIS, 1965

Proposed by **Edward Jones** and **Keith Davis**, Correspondent Inference Theory explains how we draw conclusions about a person's underlying **traits and dispositions** directly from their behaviour — particularly when that behaviour appears to be **freely chosen and intentional**.

## The Core Claim

We infer that a person's behaviour *corresponds* to a stable, internal trait. If someone acts aggressively, we conclude they are an aggressive person — not simply reacting to circumstances.

## When It Applies

Correspondent inferences are strongest when behaviour is deliberate and chosen freely. Accidental or coerced behaviour tells us much less about who a person truly is.

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# Key Factors in Correspondent Inference

Jones and Davis identified three critical factors that determine how confident we are in drawing a correspondent inference — that is, concluding that behaviour reflects a person's true character.

1

### Choice

If the behaviour was **freely chosen** (not forced or expected), it is far more informative about personality. Freely chosen actions carry greater inferential weight.

2

### Social Desirability

**Uncommon or socially unexpected** behaviour reveals more about a person. Acting in line with social norms tells us little — deviating from them tells us a great deal.

3

### Non-Common Effects

When a chosen action has **unique outcomes** not achievable by alternatives, those effects pinpoint the true motive. The fewer the unique effects, the clearer the inference.

*Example:* A student who voluntarily chooses the hardest assignment — when easier ones were available — is likely inferred to be **hardworking and ambitious**.

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# Kelley's Causal Attribution Theory

HAROLD KELLEY, 1967

Harold Kelley proposed that people approach the task of attribution much like **scientists** — systematically observing patterns of behaviour across different situations, people, and time to identify the most logical cause.

## The Covariation Model

Kelley's framework, known as the **Covariation Model**, suggests that we attribute behaviour to whatever factor *covaries* most consistently with it. Just as a scientist looks for correlations in data, we look for patterns in behaviour before assigning a cause.

This model assumes we have access to multiple observations over time — making it a **rational, logical** approach to understanding human behaviour.

### Key Insight

Unlike Correspondent Inference Theory, which focuses on a single act, Kelley's model emphasises **repeated patterns** across situations — making it especially powerful for explaining consistent behaviour.

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# Kelley's Three Factors: The Covariation Model

Kelley proposed that we use three types of information — **Consensus**, **Consistency**, and **Distinctiveness** — to determine whether a cause is internal (the person) or external (the situation).

### Consensus

Do **other people** behave the same way in the same situation? High consensus points to an external cause.

### Consistency

Does this person behave this way **every time** the situation occurs? High consistency suggests a stable cause.

### Distinctiveness

Does this person behave this way **only in this specific situation**? High distinctiveness suggests an external cause.

**Classic Example:** A student laughs at a teacher's joke. If *everyone* laughs (high consensus), *they always laugh* at this teacher (high consistency), and *only at this teacher* (high distinctiveness) → we make an **external attribution**: the teacher is genuinely funny.

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# Attitude: Concept & Definition

PART 2: ATTITUDE

An **attitude** is a learned, relatively stable evaluation of a person, object, idea, or situation — expressed along a continuum from **very positive** to **very negative**. Attitudes are not innate; they are shaped by our experiences, culture, and social environment.

### Evaluative in Nature

Attitudes involve a judgement — we are not neutral. We evaluate things as good or bad, desirable or undesirable, and these evaluations guide our responses.

### Learned Through Experience

We acquire attitudes through direct experience, observation, and social influence. They can change over time — though strongly held attitudes are remarkably resistant to change.

### Influences Behaviour

Attitudes predispose us to act in certain ways. A positive attitude towards exercise, for instance, makes it more likely we will actually engage in physical activity.

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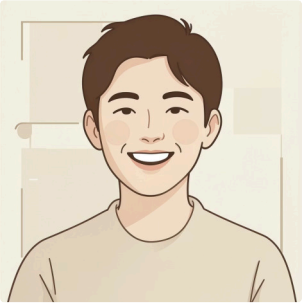
# The Three Components of Attitude

Psychologists describe attitude as having three distinct but interconnected components — often called the **ABC Model**. Together, they capture the full picture of how we evaluate and respond to the world.

## Cognitive Component

Our **beliefs and thoughts** about an object or idea. *"Regular exercise is good for my health"* — this belief forms the cognitive basis of the attitude.



## Affective Component

Our **feelings and emotions** associated with the object. *"I genuinely enjoy exercising"* — this emotional response reinforces or shapes the attitude.

## Behavioural Component

Our **actions and intentions** toward the object. *"I exercise three times a week"* — behaviour is the observable expression of the underlying attitude.

> Thank you for your attention! Understanding attribution and attitude gives us powerful tools to decode human behaviour — both in others and in ourselves.

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